Besides the assignment of his wealth, his will contained an advice to his wife. It reflected a liberal outlook much ahead of their times. In it, he expressed his ‘earnest desire’ for his wife, even after his death, to ‘move about and mix into society as she had been doing in his lifetime, and [she] should dress and deck herself quite regardless of the custom to the contrary prevailing amongst the Parsees’.

Navajbai Sett, later Lady Tata, was born on 23 September 1877 to Ardeshir Merwanji Sett. The Setts were an extraordinarily rich Parsi trading family. The affluence of the family was evident in the several residences that they owned on the upscale Peddar Road in Bombay (now Mumbai). At the age of fifteen, in 1892, she married Sir Ratan Tata and later, they shifted residence to England.

There they lived in the magnificent residence York House, once owned by Louis-Philippe-Robert, duke d’Orléans, pretender to the French throne. The building was situated on a rising elevation facing the Thames. The three-storeyed York House had an exquisite garden extending down to the river. The locality of the house was ‘one of the most agreeable places of residence in England’.

Sir Ratan and Lady Tata upgraded the residence by making several additions. They included ‘statues of naked female figures, some in highly unusual attitudes,’ ‘a group of life-size sea-nymphs and horses disporting themselves,’ which ‘adorn[ed] a cascade and pool in the riverside portion of the gardens’. The quality of the Carrara marbles that the statues were made of was so exquisite that they were masked with green sludge during the Second World War to prevent ‘enemy bombers from being guided up the Thames’.

In this extraordinary setting, the couple led a life of opulence and style ‘with no less than twenty servants in livery’, enough to arouse the envy of the aristocracy of England. The house witnessed some of the most elaborate ‘Edwardian’ parties of the time, attended by King George V and Queen Mary. One of the parties had around 1,500 guests who had arrived in their ‘stately carriages’. The social interactions expanded their horizons, freeing them from the restricting practices of their native India and religion.

Lady Tata became a proficient horse rider and also tried her hand at polo. She would stand ‘ramrod straight’, Ratan says of her. He adds that she represented a pleasant and balanced blend of Indian and British culture. She